



FISHING AND MARICULTURE

People have been fishing in coastal waters since prehistoric times, and many ancient fishing techniques are still used today. But commercial fishing has now become a major industry, with fleets of ships equipped with advanced technology for finding, catching, and processing fish. Many species of fish are also reared in captivity, in various forms of mariculture such as fish farms and shrimp pools.

▲ COASTAL FISHING

Most coastal communities practice some form of fishing to supply the nearby markets. These simple techniques yield just enough fish to meet the local demand. Since they are rarely intensive enough to threaten fish populations, the fishermen never run out of fish to catch. They are not very profitable, but they are sustainable—provided the same waters are not used for industrial fishing as well.



◀ OCEANIC FLEETS

Most of the fish that are eaten worldwide are caught by fleets of big fishing boats that stay at sea for months. Their catch is processed and refrigerated on board, or on factory ships. Such fishing fleets venture as far as the Southern Ocean, although most of the fishing takes place in the north Atlantic and north Pacific Oceans, and in the rich seas off Chile and Peru.

NETS AND LINES ►

The simple drift nets once used for sea fishing have given way to purse seine nets that surround and trap entire shoals, and big trawl nets that scoop up huge numbers of bottom-feeding fish such as cod. Tuna are often caught on longlines with up to 10,000 baited hooks, trailing up to 75 miles (120 km) behind the ship.

